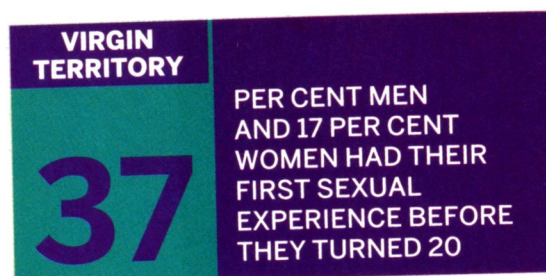




How active were you sexually after the first time?

		Male	Female
Once	12	14	9
Sometimes	42	46	36
Often	44	37	53
Till I turned 18	3	3	2

For 3,923 respondents of the total of 5,353 who have had sex. Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent. The figures have been rounded off to the nearest integer.



Chandigarh's Kalagram arts village complex.

This year's INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG SEX survey captures this attitudinal sea change as young men and women across India shed their prudish pasts and embrace a new era of openness. Out of 5,353 respondents, 37 per cent men and 17 per cent women claim to have had their first sexual experience before age 20. Premarital sex finds favour among women in most metros, with Delhi girls topping the charts at 27 per cent. If the previous generation found first sex mostly in marriage (60 per cent with wives), for the youth brigade sexual awakening happens in casual relationships, namely "friends". For a culture that has long kept hidden its sexuality under wraps, sex is now on display—in movies, soap operas, media and among young couples canoodling in parks. No wonder, 37 per cent of young men and women like to "talk" about their encounters. But for all the dare, their approach to sex is straightlaced: 83 per cent don't approve of sex with sex workers, 68 per cent don't believe in sexual experimentation, 92 per cent have never used sex toys, 71 per cent prefer men-on-top, 81 per cent are heterosexual and 86 per cent don't approve of homosexuality.

Underneath, however, the love life of teen India is teeming with ignorance. Studies show that young Indians do not know enough about sex. Delhi-based TARSHI, which runs a helpline on sexual information, received over 59,000 calls last year from young men, seeking information on women's anatomy, the "suhag raat", what would happen if they failed to perform on

the first night and how to make their wives happy and sexually fulfilled. Over 33 per cent of the callers were between ages 15 and 24. In 2005, the Kamasutra sex survey among people in the age band of 18 to 30 in Delhi, Mumbai and Bangalore reported that the majority acquired their knowledge primarily through "self-reading", "friends" and "blue films" or the brutal mechanics of Internet porn. The survey, too, shows up the primacy of porn: while 42 per cent men and women across age bands got into pornography first as a teenager, 62 per cent watch it regularly. Be it girls or boys, their partners in crime and curiosity are invariably friends (nearly 50 per cent).

"Yes, definitely, young India is talking more openly about sex," says Sudhakar Krishnamurti, author of *Sex is Not a Four-Letter Word* and director of Andromeda Andrology Center, Hyderabad. A lot of it is happening on the Internet. Nearly 60 per cent of Internet users are below age 25 in India, says the India Online 2007 user behaviour survey by research consultants Juxt-Consult. Nineteen-year-old Mukesh of Hans Raj College of Delhi sums up the spirit of the time. "It's not like in the old days when it was like, 'Oh, please tell me what it's like to have sex!'," he says. "If I wanted to know, I could go online and talk to somebody random."

Just a rite of passage? Or a silent revolution in the making?

For past surveys, interactive graphics visit:
www.indiatoday.in/sexsurvey08

